

Life in Reverse

It started at a bad time. I was chugging down a thermos of coffee on my way to work when the coffee started climbing its way back up my throat. I think I'd have crashed the car soon after that experience except that the car had started moving backwards too.

I tried to steer and all that. Looking backwards, trying to keep the thing on the road, slamming the brakes. Well, none of that seemed to matter. It just kept going right along at 60 mph backwards, just like I drove it forwards to get to that point.

This really brings us to the first conundrum I've found of my situation. From my perspective, I have some sort of agency but I don't know if the agency I experience trickles down to the rest of the universe. I can turn a steering wheel just fine. I can talk to my wife, even grab a pen and write this letter. These are all things I can do from my perspective at the very least. The trouble is I don't really know which, if any, of those actions carry through to the rest of the world.

When my wife speaks, she speaks in reverse to my ears. Which was fine for a time, when I could remember what she was saying. "Have a nice day at work" and all that. But then I figure I'm probably speaking in reverse back to her. You'd think I'd know from her reaction to what I say, that she'd look shocked or concerned as I speak backwards, but since my life's playing in reverse, I never actually get to see the moment of her reaction.

It's possible nothing I do really matters now. In fact, I think that'd be preferable. I even screamed in the middle of that first night to try to wake her up. If she did wake up to my screaming it would've had to happen after I screamed it, which is a moment, like I've said, that I never make it to. I should hope there is no universe in which she wakes up to me screaming in the middle of the night, but sometimes I wonder how that version of myself would explain an action I only took due to the reverse logic of my present situation. So my best bet is that things I do just don't matter.

Of course, the opposite could be true. That would be the worst case. Maybe every time I take an action in reverse, there's some alternative future which splinters off of that action. That'd be a problem, cause I probably spawned a hundred trillion car crashes just in that one drive back home.

In an attempt to limit my impact on the future, I've decided to lock myself away in our guest bedroom. I figure it'd be better for my potential future selves to explain suddenly becoming a recluse to my wife than it would be to get them all killed in mysterious car accidents or something. I lock the door when I can, but I can't lock the door in the past, so sometimes she still gets in. When that happens I try to just ignore you/ her for the most part.

I think I've started to really get a hang of the reverse speech thing. It's been about as bad as learning another language, but I haven't had much else to do. Of course, understanding my wife doesn't really change much, it's just for my own leisure. I've tried to start speaking in reverse on occasion as well, but even if that helps her understand me I'm not sure what she could do with the information.

Anyways, in this room of mine I've taken to some experiments. Objects, for instance, seem to bend to my agency so long as they're in my immediate grasp. Take this pen I'm holding. I can lift it, move it around, but if I throw it, it seems to disappear after leaving my hand. I tried to write with the pen and at first I thought it was out of ink, because no line followed from the tip. After I tried a fresh pack of pens I've come to the conclusion that the pens may in fact be writing, it's just that the ink, like everything else, is in a future I never see. So I've begun writing these letters, somewhat blindly aligning the letters to where I think they ought to go. If the words are smudged together a bit, I apologize for that.

I'll slide this letter, among the few others I've written, under the door. Maybe I'll even place this one in your hands. So, if you're reading this, I love you and please contact some theoretical physicist or something.

Hey Darling,

I realize for you this is likely the first you're hearing of my predicament, but, for me, well, I've written a lot more letters than just this one. Those are in your future though, maybe you won't understand for a bit. Just please ignore the more... emotional ones for me, alright? I don't really mean it, it's just been tough, being all alone. I shouldn't really complain though. Afterall, there's only one of me stuck in this condition, and I'm potentially writing letters to an infinite number of you.

I'd like to think you get this and succeed in dragging me out of this state of reversed time that I'm in. Maybe I'm saving other versions of me with these letters.

I've started studying physics by the way! Took a stroll to a bookstore and stole a couple textbooks and stuff. I left some money that they may or may not get. I've actually been leaving my room a lot more recently. It used to be a bit strange, watching everything in reverse. You gotta watch out for cars a bit differently. If you see their brake lights come on there's a good chance they're about to accelerate back at you. I like walking by that stream near our house, but I can't drive to any waterfall, or something bigger like that. In the summers I'll watch the neighbors suck up water from their lawn into a hose. In the winters I watch snowmen crystallize out of the air before some kids come around to pull them apart.

Actually, I'm afraid to say, I've gotten a little bit bolder than just leaving my room. When you never see the consequences of your own actions, you start to see yourself as a bit of a spectre after some time. Now it's hard for me to imagine there's any consequence to any action I could take. It's funny, I used to hide in my room thinking my actions were too consequential, but now I think nobody else ever gave a shit about statistical, theoretical consequences of their actions, so why should I, you know?

I say that, but I've never murdered anyone or anything like that. I'll walk into people's homes though, on occasion. At first the taboo of it was fun, but once that faded it turns out people aren't doing too much of interest. You might also read some letters talking about some other things I've done, but... well, just know I regret things now. Hopefully as you come to understand my position you might forgive a few of the lapses in sanity I've had to face. I still love you.

That brings us to another pressing matter. You see, things have been this way for me for a while now. Long enough that I've watched a wrinkle or two smooth off over time, and I promise I haven't been stealing those face masks of yours. I'd be happy about it, but the thing is I think the fold in my brain must be doing something similar. See, I can remember my experiences from all this time in reverse, the coffee thing and all that, but the memories of my time spent forward, particularly the moments of time after my present, are growing hazier and hazier.

I think, in the beginning, it wasn't such an issue, because each day I spent in that room I'd think about what happened on that day in reverse. In that process, I think I consolidated those memories into my reverse life. But then I started leaving the room. I stopped caring about what I'd done on this or that day in forward motion. But then my brain got younger too, and so those wrinkles of memory were smoothed right out of my brain, as they'd yet to happen.

Take what you said to me, before this all started. "Have a nice day at work." I know you said that before I left, I remember thinking about it in the car driving backwards. I remember you saying it in reverse when I got home, I remember all the times I reimagined that memory in all the letters I've sent you. I know you said it, but the original memory is gone. Erased. Now all I have are cheap copies of that memory. Or rather, at least I have cheap copies of that memory.

The longer this goes on there are so many memories I know I'm losing. I try to keep a calendar. Watch what you do and remember each day, consolidating you into this new phantom sort of memory as best that I can, but yesterday was our third anniversary. For me, it didn't mark three years into our marriage, but rather, three years left. That brings me back to my present pursuits in studying physics.

I first began my studies in total, earnest simplicity. I relearned mathematics which I hadn't seen since high school, intending to build up my comprehension in a more principled and thorough manner. However, I now know that for every day I twiddle my fingers on quadratic formulas and trigonometry I lose a day with you. So I've skipped to the more advanced, even esoteric stuff. Something which might at least grant me a grain of understanding.

To make a long story short, the present Standard Model of Physics is nearly totally complete. Just about everything which can happen in our world can be explained by the standard model of Physics. Even the most minute interactions of tiny particles being slammed into one another at 99.99% the speed of light can be explained by the current model. In fact, to my dismay, it seems to me that physicists are at such a point where the greatest difficulty is not in explaining the world, but rather in finding an experiment which they cannot explain. Unfortunately, I as a whole seem to exist outside their models.

The most promising theory I have as to my own condition is that it has something to do with quantum mechanics. This is the most "spooky" domain of physics where point-like particles can tunnel through material, a product of particles existing in probability clouds. Presently, it seems that physicists treat position and momentum as two operators in their calculations. But how absurd would it be to imagine time is another operator, rather than an external parameter? I'd imagine the average educated physicist would say that it's a "very absurd" notion, but put them in my shoes and they just might reconsider.

The other trouble with quantum mechanics is that it only operates on things which are very miniscule, dry, and cold. Large, warm, damp things such as my brain don't really fit the bill. Perhaps there is some corner of my brain responsible for my conscious existence, small enough

that it alone has been perpetually sent spiraling backwards in time. There's barely even a wisp of hope within this idea but I'll cling to it for as long as I can.

Dear Darling,

We got married today. For you. For me, we got divorced. It's always kind of uncanny. People talking to where I used to be. They smiled and cheered for you walking down the aisle all by yourself from my perspective. I hate to admit this, but I heard your vows for the first time today. The first time I was too nervous repeating my lines in my head to actually hear you. Admittedly, even this time it was difficult to understand through the tears and in reverse as it was.

I should say now, my scientific endeavors have failed. For all my wild speculations and theories, I have no way to put them into any sort of practice which might reverse what's happening to me. I have even tried many things far from logical. Prayers and rituals. Ouija boards and other spirit divinations. None of these have worked. I've even tried blood sacrifices to the best of my abilities. It's difficult to bleed when the wounds I try to create in myself only bleed going forward in time. This means, from my perspective, the wound appears to heal the moment after I've made it. It doesn't matter though, the offerings have never worked.

I can't stand the thought of continuing this existence much longer. I only live for you and even that is fading rapidly. I listen to our conversations in reverse, but now I can't remember what we were talking about or what I was saying. Memories of memories of memories of memories and I can't tell which conversations were real and which are my own imaginations. I can't even remember who I used to be

It is a certain kind of hell. I live every day with you, but each day I forget more than I remember. Today we're divorced, but soon you won't be in my life at all. I'll get younger and I'll forget more, and then I'll get younger still. Perhaps someday I'll revert into a baby, crying endlessly and wondering why I have no mother to respond to my cries. For this reason, I've decided to kill myself.

I've worked out a few ways to do it. A gun is off the table. I can pull the trigger, but as soon as the bullet leaves the chamber it will no longer be under my immediate agency. It will disappear like anything that I throw. I can't eat or drink as would be typical, and I find myself always in the same fitness as I was at the age of my body. If I attempt to drink alcohol, somewhere in my throat it will reverse course back to the bottle. This means I can't get drunk of my own volition, but I do get drunk at the random hours when I was drunk in forward life. This fact means I can't assume any ordinary mix of pills will digest.

The solution I've come to is a grenade. The fuse might stop ticking down should it ever leave my grasp. The explosion as well might, in most places, leave my grasp and move only in forward time. But a portion of the shockwave, the portion traveling within my hand, clasped to my chest, might maintain within my agency, stuck in the same reverse logic that traps me. Maybe that will kill me. I could test this idea with an electric shock to see how it flows through me, the trouble is outside of my own body electricity still flows in reverse, effectively flowing

away from ground and towards the source. Since I'm not a source of electricity, this is an issue. So, I think the grenade will have to be a test of its own. One I should hope not to survive.

I'm sorry if you ever read this. While it is hopefully my last letter, if you discover this as soon as it is written, I know it would be your first of these letters. So I'll hide it in our attic. In five years time I know you'll go digging around up there. By then, maybe this letter will come as a relief. I hate to bother you with the details of my death, but the world deserves to know. Just in case of the awful event where someone else finds themselves trapped as I am.

I live my life in a backward world where rivers flow up to mountain tops, water melts to ice, and everything falls out of place. But among all this backwardness, I can't bear to see myself revert to a time before you. Know that I'll love you all throughout time, whichever way it chooses to swirl.